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The Resilience of Generation Z

Growing up in the small town of Potosi, Missouri, I lived in the same small house in the middle of town for 17 years. I had a purple bike that I often rode up and down the paved road, a small fenced-in backyard where I would imagine adventures and build stick forts, and the gravel alleyway where I used to run; All of these things helped keep me entertained. However, I rarely wanted to be anywhere else. I didn't roam around on unknown roads and didn't hang out with friends very often; instead, I stayed content with my familiar surroundings and the quiet patterns and routines that shaped my days. Calmness and comfort came from the known paved roads of town, every familiar face that I saw almost every day, and places that felt like home.

For Generation Z, comfort often comes from the predictable and stable, particularly in this rapidly changing world. For the members of Generation Z, growing up during a time of economic uncertainty, global crises, and rapid technological changes has made stability rare and valuable for many. In a world that constantly pushes the boundaries of people to move faster and look ahead, the predictability of things that are close to us provides a strong sense of grounding, reflecting a broader desire among Gen Z for comfort, safety, and belonging. Generation Z has overcome many challenges in their lifetime and has bounced back from them, becoming even stronger; this is why our generation is considered resilient.

Most members of Generation Z have come of age during the COVID-19 pandemic, and as the children of Generation X, Gen Zers have grown up in the aftermath of 9/11 and the Great

Recession. This illustrates the major historical events that shaped Generation Z. These events affected our sense of security, education, and daily life during our formative years. This is important because these shared experiences help to explain our values and behaviors, such as their adaptability and stability. Growing up with these issues has allowed Gen Z members to be more prepared for the future and able to overcome more during crises, although they are more cautious. Generation Z was hit with the Coronavirus in 2020, while adults were slowly losing their jobs, and children were ripped out of valuable years of schooling and told to stay inside the comfort of their own homes to stop the rapid spread of this virus. This event has caused many people to continue to look forward in a negative mindset, having the feeling that everything will continue to just go downhill. According to the author of McKinsey & Company, “This pessimism is fueled by growing global unrest, wars, and disruptions, financial crises, and educational interruptions due to the COVID-19 pandemic. Feelings of 'climate anxiety' are also widely reported: many Gen Zers report that they think about the fate of the planet daily.” These sentences state that many people in this generation feel negatively affected by ongoing global problems, including war, economic struggles, and educational disruptions caused by the COVID-19 pandemic. It highlights how constant exposure to global crises affects the outlook of Gen Z on the future. Understanding the worries helps explain rising anxiety levels in this generation. They show why emotional support, climate action, and stability are important for improving their growth and well-being. When these global crises were happening, they had no concept of what the future would look like. However, this generation eventually overcame this illness but proceeded with some precautions.

Global crises are not the only thing that this generation had to withstand. Generation Z is known to be the only generation that truly grew up with technology, which is something that we

use to become stronger, although it does have some weaknesses. Generation Z, the first generation never to know the world without the internet, values diversity, finds their own unique identities, and quickly finds information, says Stanford scholar Roberta Katz. This means that we have grown up with constant internet access, which has highly influenced how we learn, interact with others, and understand ourselves. Because of this environment, we have learned to have different values. For example, we have learned to appreciate diversity, actively working to form unique identities, and relying on quick access to information to navigate daily life and complex issues. The author Hayden Rahn explained that in a survey taken in 2017 by a Boston-based agency of 1,000 consumers between the ages of 18 and 24 regarding social media, it showed that more than 70 percent of Generation Z members believed that people around their same age are distracted by technology, and more than half seek relief from social media. This shows that a majority of Generation Z recognizes that too much use of technology can be distracting and harmful. Rather than being unfamiliar with or detached from social media, many individuals are consciously thinking about how social media affects their focus, mental health, and daily lives, and are actively seeking ways to step back from it. This is helpful because acknowledging a problem and taking steps to address it requires self-awareness and resilience. In a generation that has grown up surrounded by constant digital use, Gen Z's willingness to disconnect, set boundaries, and prioritize well-being shows adaptability, strength, and resilience.

Instead of being controlled by technology, we are learning how to manage it, demonstrating resilience in the face of a highly distracting digital environment. The Anne E. Casey Foundation stated that with these technological advancements, there are positive effects on Generation Z members. These effects include an abundance of information at their fingertips, allowing them to broaden their knowledge, access resources, and be proactive in their learning.

In this generation, technology allows for quick and easy access to information and sources with just a click of a few buttons, helping this generation learn more and take control of their education. To this day, we have many different sources that Generation Z uses almost every day to help them learn in and outside of school, and in many different situations. These can include different sources such as ChatGPT, Google, and GPT-zero. Generation Z has really used technology and these sources for the betterment of society. The author of the Pew Research Center stated that Generation Z is more racially and ethnically diverse than any other generation, and they are on track to become the smartest generation yet. They are also digital natives who have little memory of the world before the widespread use of technology. These sentences explain how this generation, with many different races and backgrounds, has started to become the most educated so far. These also highlight that our generation has grown up with smartphones and digital technology, while using the internet and devices makes this feel natural to this generation.

This generation has not only overcome the Coronavirus Pandemic and growing up with technology, but they have also been able to withstand mental health challenges. Gen Zers face higher anxiety and stress levels, but their resilience shows up when they are willing to openly speak about mental health, seek help, and challenge negative stereotypes that previous generations ignored. Mental health issues are a sad characteristic of our Generation Z, sometimes being called the “loneliest generation”. Heavy spending time online can cause feelings of anxiety, depression, isolation, and other mental health issues (The Anne E. Casey Foundation). Many members in our generation struggle with mental health, which is worsened by the time spent online, and do not have face-to-face interaction. Despite the struggles, our generation shows resilience by acknowledging the issues instead of ignoring them. Instead of fighting these

battles in silence, many seek support and help, advocate for mental health awareness, and work to help set healthier boundaries. Their ability to recognize the problem and respond to it shows emotional strength and adaptability in the face of ongoing psychological pressure. With the unrest surrounding issues like gun violence, police brutality, and climate change, leading to increased levels of stress. Additionally, societal crises and stressors have had a major impact as well (The Anne E. Casey Foundation). This explains how our generation is growing up through political and social unrest. These events and crises have caused major stress levels for these members of this generation, leaving them to have to adapt to what is going on around them. This shows importance because, instead of being apathetic and disengaged. Despite the pressure, Generation Z has shown resilience by staying active, involved, and informed in these issues. Many members of our generation cope with their stress through community involvement, activism, and advocacy, using their voices to encourage change while navigating uncertainty. Their ability to face multiple large-scale crises at once and still participate in shaping society demonstrates adaptability, persistence, and emotional strength. Taking on these challenges can be tough but being able to persevere and make the best out of what is going on allows us to cope better with the stress and use it to our advantage. We use our voices to speak about what is going on within our society, allowing us to calm our stress levels, ultimately making our mental health better.